

purpose ever since. Its active constituent, santonin, was first isolated in 1830, and is now more commonly employed than the plant itself.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Used almost exclusively to expel worms, Levant wormwood is strongly bitter and aromatic and has a tonic and stimulant effect on digestion. The dried flower heads are occasionally mixed with honey to disguise their bitterness.

⚠ **Cautions** Do not take during pregnancy. Use only under professional supervision, especially in the case of children under 12.

Artemisia dracunculus (Asteraceae) Tarragon

Description Aromatic perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has narrow lance-shaped leaves and small greenish flower heads in long drooping clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Russia, western Asia, and the Himalayas, tarragon is now cultivated as a culinary herb in gardens around the world. The aerial parts are picked in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Tarragon contains tannins, coumarins, and flavonoids, and up to 0.8% volatile oil, consisting of up to 70% methylchervicol, which is toxic and potentially carcinogenic.



Tarragon sweetens the breath and helps to stimulate digestion.

History & Folklore Tarragon is widely used as an herb in cooking. In French, it is sometimes known as *herbe au dragon*, because of its reputed ability to cure serpent bites.

Medicinal Actions & Uses While tarragon stimulates digestion, it is reputed to be a mild sedative and has been taken to aid sleep. With its mild menstruation-inducing properties, it is taken if periods are delayed. The root has traditionally been applied to aching teeth.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy. Do not exceed the standard dose, and do not take for longer than 4 weeks at a time.

Artemisia vulgaris (Asteraceae) Mugwort

Description Shrubby perennial growing to about 3 ft (1 m). Has dark green deeply indented leaves and numerous clusters of small reddish or yellow flower heads.

Habitat & Cultivation Mugwort is found in temperate regions of the northern hemisphere. It flourishes in open areas and along roads, and is gathered in late summer just before flowering.

Parts Used Leaves, root.

Constituents Mugwort contains a volatile oil (mainly caryophyllene), a sesquiterpene lactone, flavonoids, coumarin derivatives, and triterpenes.

History & Folklore Known as *Mater Herbarum* (mother of herbs), mugwort was used from the earliest times in Europe and Asia. Roman centurions reputedly placed it in their sandals to keep the soles of their feet in good shape. The Greek physician Dioscorides (1st century CE) recounts that the goddess Artemis (who inspired the plant's genus name) was believed to give succor to women in childbirth. The 13th-century Welsh herbal *The Physicians of Myddfai* recommends: "If a woman be unable to give birth to her child let the mugwort be bound to her left thigh. Let it be instantly removed when she has been delivered, lest there should be hemorrhage." An 18th-century Spanish herbalist, Diego de Torres, recommends the application of a mugwort plaster below the navel as an effective method of inducing labor. In the Isle of Man (UK), sprigs of mugwort are worn at the annual open-air parliamentary assembly, held on Tynwald Hill. In China, mugwort has been valued for millennia. It is the principal ingredient of *moxa* and is used in moxibustion, a process in which heat from a burning, cigar-shaped roll of chopped leaves is applied to acupuncture points.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A digestive and tonic herb, mugwort has a wide variety of traditional uses. Milder in action than most other *Artemisia* species, it can be taken over the long

term at a low dose to improve appetite, digestive function, and absorption of nutrients. In addition, it can be taken to encourage the elimination of worms. Mugwort also increases bile flow and mildly induces the onset of menstruation. The European conception of mugwort as a uterine stimulant is contradicted by Chinese usage, in which it is prescribed to prevent miscarriage and to reduce or stop menstrual bleeding. Mugwort is also antiseptic, and has been used in the treatment of malaria.

Caution Do not take mugwort during pregnancy.

Asclepias tuberosa (Asclepiadaceae) Pleurisy Root

Description Perennial, upright herb growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has narrow lance-shaped leaves and spikes of numerous 5-petaled orange or yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb is native to the southern U.S. The root is unearthed in spring.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Pleurisy root contains cardenolides and flavonoids. It is estrogenic.

History & Folklore In North American herbal medicine, pleurisy root was considered a cure-all. It was used to treat conditions as diverse as pleurisy, typhoid, pneumonia, congestion, dysentery, colic, eczema, and hysteria. The Omaha ate the raw root for bronchitis and other chest conditions. Many tribes thought pleurisy root was a good remedy for hot dry fevers.

Medicinal Actions

& Uses Though its most specific usage is relieving the pain and inflammation of pleurisy, pleurisy root has other applications. It is useful for hot, dry, and tight conditions in the chest. It promotes the coughing up of phlegm, reduces inflammation, and, in addition,



Pleurisy root was used by Native Americans as a chest remedy.